

Impact: High Difficulty: Medium Misuse risk: Low

## CORE FORMULA

**Disagree with the idea -> Stay curious -> No dismissal signals**

## MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before disagreeing, check your face and tone. Remove any dismissal — eye-roll, sigh, 'obviously', sarcasm. Then disagree with the position, not the person.

## BEST FOR

- High-stakes disagreements where the relationship must stay intact
- Peer-to-peer pushback in professional settings
- Disagreeing with someone more senior without damaging the relationship
- Debates where you are likely to be wrong about something

## PHRASE BANK

### Disagreement Openers · Stating the difference without contempt

- "I see this differently — my view is..."
- "I do not think that is quite right, and here is why."
- "I want to push back on one specific part of that."
- "I disagree, and I want to explain my reasoning."
- "That is not how I read the situation — here is my read."
- "I would reach a different conclusion from the same data."
- "I think there is a better option, and I want to explain why."
- "I have a different view on this, and I think it matters."

### Curiosity Phrases · Staying open while disagreeing

- "Help me understand how you got there."
- "I want to make sure I am disagreeing with what you actually said."
- "Is there something I am missing that would change my view?"
- "Walk me through the part I am not seeing."
- "I might be wrong — what would change your position?"
- "I want to understand your reasoning before I push back harder."

### Disagreeing Upward · Pushing back on someone senior

- "Can I offer a different read before we lock this in?"
- "I want to flag a risk in this plan while there is still time to adjust."
- "You may well see something I do not — from where I sit, X looks like a problem."
- "I would not be doing my job if I did not raise this."
- "If we go this route, I want my concern on the record — then I am fully behind the decision."
- "May I push back on one part of that?"

### Meeting Disagreement · Dissent that keeps the room working

- "I want to offer a counter-view so we pressure-test this properly."
- "Before we converge — can I argue the other side for two minutes?"
- "I agree with the goal and disagree with the route."
- "There is a version of this I could support — it differs in one key way."
- "Let me steelman the proposal first, then say where I part ways."

## Heat Reducers · When the disagreement got sharp

- "That came out harder than I intended. The disagreement stands; the edge does not."
- "We have drifted from the issue to each other. Can we come back to the issue?"
- "I am arguing to win instead of to understand. Let me reset."
- "We clearly both care about this. That is a good starting point."
- "Can we take five and come back to it? I want to disagree better than this."

## WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Dismissive sigh, eye-roll, or 'obviously not'  
Better: I do not think that is the right approach.  
**Best: I disagree — and I want to explain my reasoning.**
2. Weak: Aggressive disagreement: 'That is completely wrong'  
Better: I do not agree with that conclusion.  
**Best: I reach a different conclusion. Here is what I am seeing.**
3. Weak: Disguised contempt: 'Well, I suppose if you want to look at it that way...'  
Better: There are other ways to look at this.  
**Best: Direct disagreement with no passive-aggressive framing.**

## DECISION TREE

### If You disagree strongly and feel contempt rising

Pause. Separate the idea from the person. Then respond.

*"I want to be direct about this without being dismissive."*

### If The other person is using contempt on you

Name it calmly without matching it.

*"I notice that landed with some edge. I would rather talk about the actual issue."*

### If You disagree but are not sure you are right

Disagree tentatively. Stay curious.

*"I think this is wrong, but I want to understand your reasoning before I say that more firmly."*

### If The disagreement is personal as well as professional

Separate the professional point from the personal dimension explicitly.

*"I want to keep this on the work question, not on the personal level."*

### If You have been right about this before and feel vindicated

Be careful. Contempt creeps in through 'told you so' energy.

*"I think this confirms the concern I raised. I am not saying I was right — I am saying the data suggests..."*

## SCENARIOS

### Colleague proposes an approach you think is flawed

Name the disagreement specifically. Stay on the idea. — "I think there is a problem with the approach, and I want to name it clearly."

### Senior person makes a claim you believe is incorrect

Disagree respectfully on the substance, not the status. — "I want to respectfully push back on that — the data I have seen suggests otherwise."

### Debate where emotions are running high

Slow down. Remove contempt signals. State disagreement plainly. — "I disagree with that and I want to explain why — without this getting heated."

### You realise mid-disagreement you might be wrong

Say so. It builds more credibility than pressing on. — "Actually — hold on. I want to reconsider that."

## WHEN NOT TO USE

- When the other person's position is genuinely harmful and requires sharp, unambiguous challenge — softness can imply

tacit endorsement.

- In high-stakes negotiations where tactical firmness is operationally necessary.
- When you have already tried respectful disagreement repeatedly and the priority is clarity over tone.

## **7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL**

### **Day 1 — Contempt audit**

Notice every time you feel contempt in a conversation today — even mild contempt. Do not act — just notice.

### **Day 2 — Separate idea from person**

In one disagreement, consciously target the idea not the person. Notice the difference.

### **Day 3 — Remove dismissal signals**

Eliminate sighs, eye-rolls, 'obviously', and sarcasm from one disagreement today.

### **Day 4 — Stay curious**

After disagreeing, ask one genuine question about their reasoning.

### **Day 5 — Direct disagreement practice**

State one disagreement plainly using 'I disagree because...' with no softening or hedging.

### **Day 6 — High-stakes practice**

Use this in one real disagreement that matters — with a colleague, manager, or partner.

### **Day 7 — Calibration**

Did your disagreements stay productive? Did the relationships hold? Was anything lost by being more direct?

## **AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST**

- Did I disagree with the idea, not the person?
- Did I remove contempt signals — tone, face, word choice?
- Did I state the disagreement plainly rather than hiding it?
- Did I stay curious about their reasoning?
- Did I avoid sarcasm, eye-rolls, and dismissive language?
- Did I stay on the substance of the disagreement?
- Did the relationship remain intact after the disagreement?
- Did I consider that I might be wrong?